

to purchase a scanner which takes less time to preview and scan a document at the ideal resolution for this segment—600 dpi.

The preview time is of great importance because, although a user may want to scan only a part of the document, every document has to be previewed completely. To test the preview time of a scanner, we previewed the document and also noted the warm-up time of the lamp. This was done because a user of this segment is not expected to use the scanner continuously and therefore the time taken to warm up between scans will be high.

The scanner that topped our chart, by taking the least time to preview the test document, was the HP Scanjet 2300c with only 11.88 seconds taken to warm-up the lamp, and preview the document in the TWAIN interface. In comparison, the Benq S2W 4300U and Umax AstraSlim 600 took as long as 24.97 seconds and 23 seconds, respectively.

This is further concretised if we look at the time logged to scan the test document at 1200 dpi, line-art mode. Keeping in mind that 1200 dpi is very high resolution, used mostly to scan small images which can later be magnified for further touch-up in imaging software; the score of HP Scanjet 2300c, at only 50.3 seconds, is impressive. This test is indicative of how the scanner will perform when used at higher resolutions. Umax



Canon, comes bundled with loads of software

AstraSlim 600 was the only scanner which overtook the HP Scanjet 2300c in the text scan test at 300 dpi line-art mode. It logged 28.67 seconds as against the 28.99 seconds logged by HP, beating it by a very tiny margin. Considering the quality of the scanned image, the 2300c was light years ahead of the Benq and Umax. With a score of 86.23 STTI, this scanner sure makes a good buy, even for home users who scan images once in a while, but like quality scans. On the feature front, both HP and Umax lag behind the Benq S2W 4300U, which has four hot keys for various functions such as scan-to-Web, scan-to-print, as compared to the two keys on the HP scanners. It also has free bundled software such as ArcSoft PhotoImpression, Acrobat Reader and MergeMagic to touch-up the image once it is scanned. Here again HP scores over the other two competitors because of its price. The 2300c is available for only Rs 3,499, making it one of the cheapest USB scanners available today in the market. Couple this with the performance and the quality of scans it is capable of, and you have the best overall scanner for less than Rs 4,000.

We recommend the HP Scanjet 2300c. With its fast warm-up time and the attractive price, it is the cheapest and best scanner available today.

Business user

Business users are a level above the home users—they need their scanner to be fast, accurate and compact. An office scanner also needs speed over quality, because not every PC will have a scanner of its own, and a solitary scanner will be shared by multiple users. For office tasks, documents are generally scanned at resolutions between 150 to 300 dpi; very few documents are scanned at higher resolutions. Thus 1200 x 2400 dpi scanners will suffice

Able Assistants

Automatic Document Feeder: ADF or Automatic Document Feeder is an accessory which is bundled with high-end scanners. This is primarily bought by the corporate and SoHo segment, where bulk scanning is needed to be done unattended. The scanner needs to have an interface that accepts this accessory. It can accept as many as 30 to 50 pages at a time and is capable of churning out a maximum of 15 pages per minute. All the user has to do is put the heap of papers to be scanned in the tray and the scanning process begins. The paper is automatically picked up from the tray, scanned and placed back into the tray. This ensures the safety of documents which might get lost if there is no proper return path. The ADF, when coupled with a scan-to-copy feature and a colour printer, will turn the scanner into a colour photocopier eliminating the high cost of buying one.



ADF is good add-on to scanner for batch scanning

Transparency Adapter: This is an accessory one will find with professional photographers. This is because a Transparency Adapter is used to scan positives and negatives, directly as an image, hence saving the cost of getting a paper print to check for quality. Photographers and designers can directly plug the negative/positive to this attachment, scan it and see the results on the screen. This also helps them to take decisions on



Detachable TPA is very handy tool for photographers

whether photos are suitable for development. A compact version of such an adapter is also available. This version sits on the top of a scanner but does not occupy the full area: making it more handy and easy to carry around.

for business users. However, quality is also required because the documents that are to be scanned come on varying media. If a scanner fails to adequately perform on a bad-quality print-medium such as a newspaper—an exercise which is frequently practised in offices—it is difficult to get an OCR-software to work accurately. The bundled accessories are also very important—an Automatic Document Feeder and Transparency adapter will make great companions in office environment.

Features such as Scan to Mail, Scan to Fax, Scan to Copy and Scan to CD are also important to speed up various processes. For instance, with an appropriate hot key, it is very easy to scan the document and automatically e-mail it to a colleague. The scanner's driver is designed to automatically select the best resolution for the document, as well as initialising your e-mail client to send the scanned file—such features are real time savers, and thus ideal for an office environment.

Thus, in this segment, features and speed become important criteria to evaluate a scanner. Although an office is not as price sensitive as a home setup, it makes little sense to purchase a scanner with features, such as a transparency adapter or a SCSI interface, which will be of little value to an office, but definitely increase the cost.